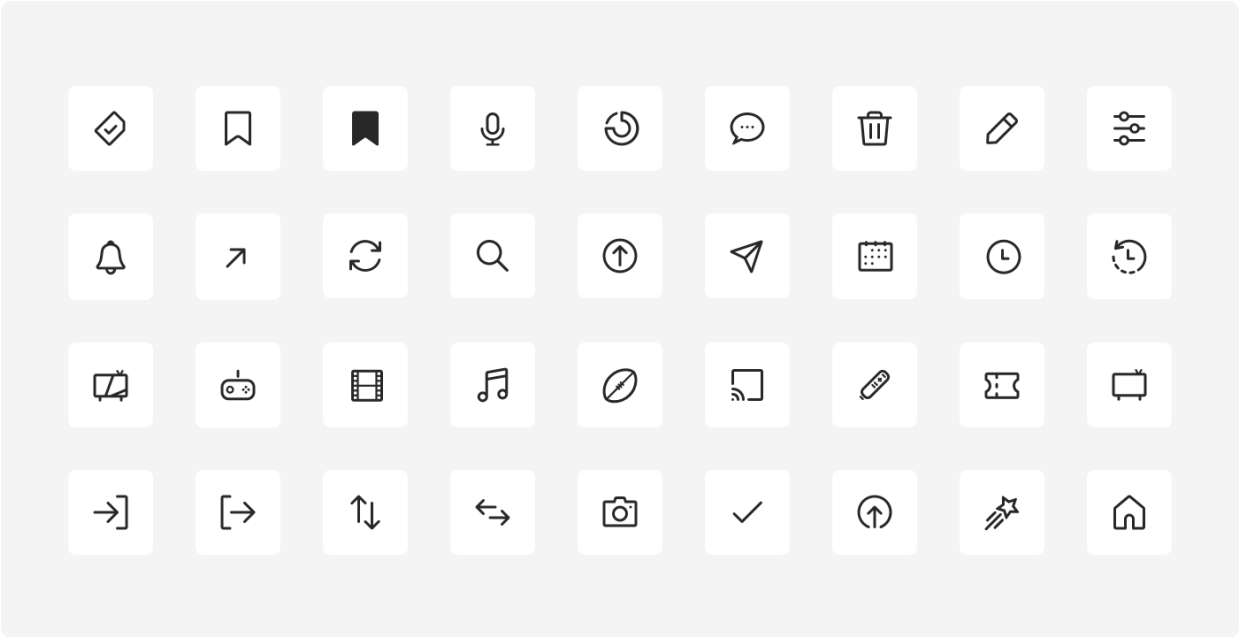
Icons

Created by Genevieve Lake, last modified by Genevieve Wang on 17 Mar 2021



Icons are symbols that provide visual representation and communicate function or intent in a universal way. They can be instantly recognisable by using monochromatic images and simplified form.

🎨 **Designers**

Guidelines

- Icon Design Guidelines
- Icon Naming Convention

Design Spec

- Colour Aliases: Icons
- Icons - Design Specifications (Android / iOS / Web)

Icon Files

- Download All Icons (via Sharepoint)

💻 **Developers**

- Web Playground
- React Playground
- Android Catalogue app
- iOS Catalogue app

Rationale

- Solid vs Hollow Icons
  Understand which type of icons are more effective in comprehension.
- Icon Naming Convention
  Guidance on how to communicate an icon's purpose through its name.
- Icon Usability

Usage

An icon can be used to:

- increase content scannability and convey the information quickly.
- represent the actions user initiate.
- replace the text where available space is limited (e.g. in Nav Bar or in mobile viewport) with a condition that the icons are universally recognisable when used standalone.
- help with people that may have cognitive or neurological impairment whereby visual works better than text.

To help overcome the ambiguity of icon, avoid using standalone icons when the icon isn't considered universal recognisable in Telstra's context. Don't use Telstra-specific icons alone without a text label.

Icon Types

There are 2 types of icons:

1. **Flexible Icons (marked with a 🌀)**
   Flexible icons are not limited to one specific action or one purpose, it can be used for multiple use cases.

   For example, " + " plus icon can be use used for expanding a view, creating a new item, or increasing the number in an input stepper.

2. **Exclusive Icons (marked with a ⭐)**
   They're reserved for a specific action or a purpose only. It should not be used to represent anything other than their established meaning.

   For example, " ⚙ " icon is reserved to represent app settings or settings of a feature. Do not use it for actions related to customisation or any other meaning.

Best Practices (For Designers)

- **Choose icons based on their recommended usage to communicate in a consistent manner.**
  All icons have their own recommended usage. Never use icons marked as exclusive to represent anything other than their established meaning.
- **Don't warp, modify or change the icon.**
  Each icon is crafted for their specific size and has custom-defined padding to provide balanced results that would fit in any UI components. Don't modify the icon in any way.
- **Never use Status icons alone.**
  Icons listed in the Status category should not be used alone, they should always be paired with a supporting text.
- **If the icon is used alone, you must provide an alternative label for accessibility.**
  Similarly to the Floating Action Button, when the icons are used alone (without text) you must provide an alternative label on that UI component for accessibility. This is so it can be announced by a screen reader.
- **Apply the correct colour aliases on icons.**
  Icons are designed to be monochromatic images and can be applied with any colour. When pairing an icon with a text, the icon colour should match the text. When using an icon in an interactive element, the icon colour should be using one of the interactive element colour aliases. Except for Status icons where their icon colour should not be modified.

- **Always use icon with a text label, except when space is limited and the icon is universal recognisable.**
  Following the icon usability recommendation from Nelson Norman Group, a text label must be present alongside an icon to clarify its meaning in that particular context and avoid confusion to users.

Best Practices (For Developers)

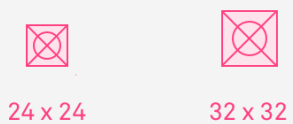
- **The colour of the icon should be linked to colour aliases.**
  Icons are template images. The colour of the icon may vary depending on where the type of UI element they are in. The icon colour should always reference one of the pre-defined colour aliases. Therefore it could adapt to light or dark appearance settings accordingly.
- **If the icon is used alone, you must provide an alternative label for accessibility.**
  If icons are used alone (without text) you must provide an alternative label for accessibility. This is so it can be announced by a screen reader.
- **Ensure icons are rendered as vectors.**
  Ensure the icons preserve vector data, so the images can smoothly scale to arbitrary sizes based on the environment settings. This would also enhance the user's accessibility experience.

For more developer guidelines on icons, see Best Practices for Web.

Icon Library

Browse icon library

Icon Sizes



In our Icon Library, each icon has two size variants—24x24 and 32x32.

For more info on picking the right icon size to pair with your text, see Icons Design Guidelines.

Accessing Icons

Icons are available in:

- Able Foundation Sketch library (Design)
- Drawables in Able-android (Android)
- Asset catalogue in Able framework (iOS)
- SVG sprites in Able library (Web)

Icon File Formats

File format is a key factor for managing and distributing a collection of icons. Choosing the right file format could significantly reduce the effort for the design and engineering team.

When choosing the suitable file format, we consider its:

1. Scalability
2. Technical effort required
3. File size

See table below for our file format recommendation for Android, iOS and Web. We also highlighted the reasons why we picked over other file formats.

Platform	Recommended Format	Key Benefits
Android	Vector Drawables (XML)	Comparing with PNGs & WEBPs • **Management** - Vector Drawables only requires 1 image file, where PNG and WEBP n 6 to cater for different resolutions. • **Size** - Vector Drawables are smaller in size in comparison to PNG & WEBP. • **Effort** - Icon colours can be easily modified in Vector Drawables where PNG & WEBP more tech efforts. • **Scalability** - Vector drawables are easily scaled without losing image quality.
iOS	PDFs	Comparing with PNGs • **Management** - PDF requires 1 image asset while PNG needs 3 images to cater differe resolutions. PDF format image with vector structure, letting us to render the image in tl resolution at run time. • **Size** - PDF file sizes are comparatively lower relative to PNG. • **Scalability** - PDFs are easily scalable with no further image quality loss. Apple's Huma Guidelines also recommends choosing PDFs over PNGs for custom icons to utilise sy provided high-resolution scaling benefits.
Web	SVG Sprites	Comparing with icon fonts • **Accessibility** - SVGs come with build in semantics which aid screen readers and they treated as images, whereas as icon fonts are treated as text which can be problematic readers. • **Positioning** - Icon fonts are inserted into the DOM as psuedo elements which inherit a parents' text styles which can be problematic. SVG are real elements which are indepe their parents' text styles as they are not text. • **Effort** - SVG spritesheets can be automated from the code base, which has all the ber version control using git, whereas icon fonts will require external applications to be bui managed manually. • **Scalability** - As Icon fonts are treated as text by browsers, they are subject to anti-alia techniques used for text, whereas SVGs will always have clean edges

If you're interested in the icon workflow, see Consumer Support for more details.

Accessibility Considerations

Icons are designed to meet the WCAG 2.1 Success Criteria outlined below. All requirements should be considered and understood when using the pattern. Requirements marked with ⚠️ indicate partial compliance or compliance must be met in build.

General

- 1.1.1 Non text content (A) - All non-text content has a text alternative that serves equivalent purpose (applicable if icon is not decorative)
  ⚠️ This requirement should be considered by designers when choosing an icon, and consulted with content, developers and producers for agreement when in development and/or authoring.
- 3.2.4 Consistent Identification (AA) - Components that have the same functionality are identified consistently.
  ⚠️ This requirement should be considered by designers when choosing an icon, and consulted with content, developers and producers for agreement when in development and/or authoring.

Design

- 1.4.11 Non Text Contrast (AA) - Icons must have a contrast ratio of at least 3:1
  Our icon colour aliases ensure we meet this requirement.
- 1.4.10 Reflow (AA) - Content can be presented without loss of information or functionality, and without requiring scrolling in two dimensions
  Our icon formats smoothly scale to arbitrary sizes based on the environment settings - however designers must still consider how icons will behave within the layout when viewing at 400%

Keyboard

There are no keyboard requirements for icons alone - these exist on the interactive element upon which the icon is placed.

Screen Readers

- Icons that provide additional information or meaning must have alternative text that is accessible to screen readers.
- Icons that do not provide any meaningful information or are decorative should be ignored by screen readers.
- Icons implemented as SVGs require some additional care to ensure they are accessible and are understood by screen readers if meaningful. For example, inline SVGS require a <title> tag to be used which is much like an alt attribute for an image.

Related Patterns

- Action Button
- Icon Button

No labels

Atlassian